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Morphological derivation, in [linguistics](#), is the process of forming a new word from an existing word, often by adding a [prefix](#) or [suffix](#), such as *un-* or *-ness*. For example, *unhappy* and *happiness* derive from the [root word](#) *happy*.

Derivational patterns [\[edit \]](#)

Here are examples of English derivational patterns and their suffixes:

- adjective-to-**noun**: -ness (*slow* → *slowness*)
- adjective-to-**verb**: -en (*weak* → *weaken*)
- adjective-to-adjective: -ish (*red* → *reddish*)
- adjective-to-**adverb**: -ly (*personal* → *personally*)
- noun-to-**adjective**: -al (*recreation* → *recreational*)
- noun-to-verb: -fy (*glory* → *glorify*)
- verb-to-adjective: -able (*drink* → *drinkable*)
- verb-to-noun (**abstract**): -ance (*deliver* → *deliverance*)
- verb-to-noun (**agent**): -er (*write* → *writer*)

When derivation occurs without any change to the word, such as in the conversion of the noun *breakfast* into the verb *to breakfast*, it's known as **conversion**, or zero derivation.

Some words have specific exceptions to these patterns. For example, *inflammable* actually means *flammable*, and *de-evolution* is spelled with only one e, as *devolution*.

Derivation can be contrasted with **inflection**, in that derivation produces a new word (a distinct **lexeme**), whereas inflection produces grammatical variants (or forms) of the same word.

A derivation can produce a lexeme with a different part of speech but does not necessarily. For example, the derivation of the word *uncommon* from *common* + *un-* (a derivational morpheme) does not change its part of speech (both are adjectives).

A non-exhaustive list of derivational morphemes in English: *-ful*, *-able*, *im-*, *un-*, *-ing*, *-er*.

A non-exhaustive list of inflectional morphemes in English: *-er*, *-est*, *-ing*, *-en*, *-ed*, *-s*.

Derivation can be contrasted with other types of **word formation** such as compounding.

Derivational affixes are **bound morphemes** – they are meaningful units, but can only normally occur when attached to another word. In that respect, derivation differs from **compounding** by which *free* morphemes are combined (*lawsuit*, *Latin professor*). It also differs from **inflection** in that inflection does not create new **lexemes** but new **word forms** (*table* → *tables*; *open* → *opened*).

Derivational patterns differ in the degree to which they can be called **productive**. A productive pattern or affix is one that is commonly used to produce novel forms. For example, the negating prefix *un-* is more productive in English than the alternative *in-*; both of them occur in established words (such as *unusual* and *inaccessible*), but faced with a new word which does not have an established negation, a native speaker is more likely to create a novel form with *un-* than with *in-*. The same thing happens with suffixes. For example, if comparing two words *Thatcherite* and *Thatcherist*, the analysis shows that both suffixes *-ite* and *-ist* are productive and can be added to proper names, moreover, both derived adjectives are established and have the same meaning. But the suffix *-ist* is more productive and, thus, can be found more often in word formation not only from proper names.

- Agglutination
- Collocation
- Inflection
- Nominalization
- Word formation
- Word root

1. ^ Crystal, David (1999): The Penguin Dictionary of Language, Penguin Books, England.
2. ^ Sobin, Nicholas (2011). *Syntactic Analysis The Basics* [↗](#). West London: Wiley-Blackwell. pp. 17–18. ISBN 978-1-4443-3895-9.

Speech and Language Processing, [Jurafsky, D.](#) & Martin J., H.

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